

CHAPTER 5: The Colonial Boomerang in the Heartland: Bardizag, Primitive Accumulation, and the Gendered Logic of Expropriation

Introduction: The destruction of the Armenian community of Bardizag in 1915 presents a fundamental historical and theoretical puzzle: why did an ecclesiastically organized community situated only fifty-six miles from Constantinople become the target of the “frontier style” demographic engineering, selective dispossession, and irregular warfare usually reserved for remote peripheries? Known in the late Ottoman era as a thriving political center and a sanctuary of communal organizing, Bardizag’s fate challenges conventional geopolitical divisions between the imperial core and its frontiers. This chapter argues that the destruction of Bardizag was an instance of genocidal expropriation, in which an Ottoman Armenian community was transformed from an autonomous political-economic society into a source of appropriable property and labor. Two frameworks explain how this transformation occurred. The colonial boomerang explains how it became possible for frontier-style violence to be deployed against a population living in the shadow of the capital. Gendered expropriation explains how that violence, once deployed, extracted different things from Armenian men, women, and children, and continued to do so long after the deportations themselves.

The colonial boomerang

The concept of the colonial boomerang, associated most prominently with Aimé Césaire and Hannah Arendt, describes the process by which coercive, repressive practices developed against marginalized populations on the imperial frontiers return to strike the metropole.¹ That such a boomerang existed in the late Ottoman Empire is not, by itself, a surprising claim: the reader

¹ Aimé Césaire, *Discourse on Colonialism*. (New York, NYU Press, 2000). Hannah Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism*.

already knows that the Ottoman state used varying registers of violence across its territory, and few historians would deny some relationship between frontier counterinsurgency and metropolitan repression in principle. The distinctive claim this chapter makes is more specific. Violent practices, personnel, and administrative knowledge developed through imperial frontier warfare were redirected toward an Armenian population situated in the imperial heartland, effectively producing an internal colonial periphery. Rather than simply returning to the metropole, imperial violence in the Ottoman case operated through the active creation of “internal peripheries.” The Ottoman state did not wait for the boomerang to return unbidden; instead, it turned frontier-tested counterinsurgency and demographic techniques inward, rendering a highly proximate, economically integrated population peripheral in the shadow of the capital.

Following the insights of Connor Woodman, this boomerang can be understood as operating through three entangled moments: violence is forged on the frontier; it is carried inward by specialized personnel for whom participation in that violence becomes a career escalator; and these techniques are then applied to populations previously considered integrated into the empire’s economic and administrative core. Men like Istanbul prison governor Ibrahim Bey and district governor Ali Şuuri Bey embody this dynamic. Ibrahim Bey represented the extralegal, paramilitary arm of the Ottoman state apparatus. He had forged his violent repertoire in the Balkan regions and the 1909 Adana pogrom; two critical frontiers of the ethno-national conflict, before being dispatched to the Izmit region.² His career demonstrates how participation in anti-Armenian violence, organized around the production of ethno-racial difference served not as a breach of administrative duty, but as a primary political qualification and a mechanism for institutional promotion. Ali Şuuri Bey represents the highly educated, technocratic face of the

² Nahiye Bardizag (BAHCECIK), *Virtual Genocide Memorial*, <https://www.virtual-genocide-memorial.de/region/the-black-sea-marmara-and-aegean-littorals-eastern-thrace-and-central-anatolia/bursa-prousa-vilayet-province/mutesarif-at-izmit/kaza-izmit-nicomedia/nahiye-bardizag-bahcecik/> (accessed date: 09/04/2026). Richard G. Hovannisian and Manuk-Khaloyan, Armen, *The Armenian Communities of Asia Minor: A Pictorial Essay*; in: *The Armenian Communities of Asia Minor*, ed. R.G. Hovannisian (Costa Mesa, CA: Mazda Publishers, 2014), p.16.

CUP state. A 1912 graduate of the prestigious *Mülkiye* (School of Civil Administration), Ali Şuuri had served on the staff of the governor of Thessaloniki and had been captured by Greek forces before being reassigned to the staff of the governor of İzmit, ultimately becoming the director of Bardizag in May 1914.³ In Turkish nationalist historiography, he is described as having carried out “the duties” assigned to him with “sincerity and dedication” during this period.⁴ After Bardizag, he continued his administrative career: district governor of Ayancık in August 1916, and police chief of Kastamonu in July 1917.

The collaboration between these two men; the technocratic administrator and the paramilitary prison director, crystallized the disintegration of conventional security structures on the ground, a disintegration further manifested through the deployment of irregular forces in civilian dress. As Ryan Gingeras has argued, the origins of what became organized paramilitary and criminal networks in Turkey are deeply intertwined with the late nineteenth-century sociopolitical landscape of the South Marmara region, where the boundaries between state authority and paramilitary violence were deliberately obscured.⁵ For perpetrators like Ibrahim Bey and Ali Şuuri, the systematic expropriation of Armenian wealth was not an incidental byproduct of war but a foundational mechanism of career advancement; violence converted into administrative expertise and, eventually, political capital. Ali Şuuri Bey and the limits of rupture

The end of the Committee of Union and Progress regime did not automatically erase the institutional, personal, or material consequences of the genocide it had organized. Ali Şuuri Bey’s

³ Vekillerimiz Şuuri Hoşafcı, *TBMM*, <https://vekillerimiz.com/vekil/ali-suuri-bey-suuri-hosafci-624/> (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

⁴ Kazım Öztürk, *Turkish Parliamentary History, TBMM – 2nd Term 1923–1927*, Vol. 3, Ankara, 1995, pp. 455–456; Fahri Çoker, *Turkish Parliamentary History, TBMM – 4th Term 1931–1935*, Vol. 2, Ankara, 1996, p. 85; Mücellidoğlu Ali Çankaya, “With Important Events of the Last Century of Turkish History,” *Yeni Mülkiye Tarihi ve Mülkiyeliler (Mülkiye Honor Book)*, Vol. 4, Ankara, 1968–1969, p. 1545.

⁵ Ryan Gingeras, “Beyond Istanbul’s ‘Laz Underworld’: Ottoman Paramilitarism and the Rise of Turkish Organized Crime, 1908-1950,” *Contemporary European History*, Vol.19, No.3. *Aftershocks: Violence in Dissolving Empires after the First World War* (August 2010), pp. 215-230.

postwar career demonstrates this with unusual clarity, and it gives this chapter's argument about the Republic a concrete example of personnel continuity and political rehabilitation. During the Armistice period, he was tried by the Martial Court, chaired by Esat Pasha, for his role in the deportation of Armenians. Among the witnesses whose written testimony was read at that hearing, Tanaş Efendi stated that İbrahim Bey had ordered detainees to be beaten; Karabet from İzmit testified that İbrahim Bey imprisoned approximately fifteen Armenians and had them beaten by gendarmes; and Artin Kürekçiyan likewise stated that İbrahim Bey arrested him and that he and other detainees were beaten. The merchant Mihran Semerciyan gave evidence of Ali Şuuri Bey's own extortion during the deportations.⁶

The tribunal did not end Ali Şuuri's career. Following his release, he returned to Balıkesir and, in April 1920, was elected a member of the Central Committee of National Defense. A few months later, he was appointed district governor of Balya by the National Government. He was captured by Greek forces on the İvrindi front; after the Armistice of Mudanya, he was exchanged and returned to Turkey in June 1923. He was elected as a deputy for Balıkesir in the 1923, 1927, and 1931 elections and served in the Turkish Grand National Assembly until his death of a sudden stroke on July 20, 1934. The point of this trajectory is not that the Republic was simply the CUP continued; that claim is too broad to defend on the evidence of one career.

Expropriation, not simply destruction

The chapter also draws on Nancy Fraser's historical analysis on the political economy of capitalism, specifically her crucial distinction between *exploitation* and *expropriation*. While exploitation operates through the formalized market mechanisms of the wage contract, expropriation represents accumulation by other means; the coercive, extra-economic seizure of property, labor, and personhood.⁷ This process of primitive accumulation, which Karl Marx

⁶ Nejdett Bilgi, "İzmit Tehciri Davası,"

⁷ Nancy Fraser, "Expropriation and Exploitation in Racialized Capitalism: A Reply to Michael Dawson," *Critical*

described as inscribed “in blood and fire,” advanced in the Ottoman context through the tandem (synonym) operations of physical extermination and wealth transfer.⁸ Critically, as the pioneering work of Anahit Astoyan demonstrates, this expropriation cannot be reduced to the mere confiscation of material wealth, such as land, houses, and vineyards.⁹ Rather, genocidal violence targeted human capacity itself; systematically seizing, redirecting, and capitalizing (another word?) bodies, unfree labor, and physical existence of the Armenian population.

The Armenian case in Bardizag demonstrates both exploitation and expropriation, and holding them together yields a claim that is stronger, and more defensible, than a purely material one. The point is not that the genocide happened because people wanted Armenian property; that formulation is too reductive, and it collapses extermination into a simple motive. The stronger argument is that genocidal policy created the conditions under which Armenian property, labor, and human capacity could be systematically appropriated and redistributed. The genocide did not simply eliminate Armenian economic actors: it appropriated the material and human capacities that their elimination made available. That distinction between motive and mechanism organizes the rest of this chapter, which traces that mechanism across five sites: the administrative dismantling of Bardizag itself (Section II); the different forms this dismantling took for men, women, and children (Section III); the recursive, repeating structure of expropriation as it operated on one survivor, Arshalous Patoogian (Section IV); the relocation rather than termination of extraction once deportees reached Syria (Section V); and the afterlives of this process in postwar disappearance, humanitarian documentation, and the institutional continuities of the Turkish Republic (Section VI).

Historical Studies, Volume 3, Number 1, 2016. *Cannibal Capitalism: How our System is Devouring Democracy, Care, and the Planet – and What We Can Do About It*. (London: Verso Books, 2022).

⁸ Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy, Vol.1*, (Vintage: 1977), p.875.

⁹ Anahit Astoyan, *The Pillage of The Century. Expropriation of Armenians in The Ottoman Empire 1914-1923* (Դարի Կողմնակալ չափերի ՌԲնեցողությունը Օսմանյան Կայսրությունում 1914-1923 թթ). (Yerevan : Nairi, Armenia, 2015).

II. Producing Expropriability

The deportation and destruction of Bardizag's Armenian community in August 1915 was not an uncoordinated outburst of wartime violence but a meticulously sequenced administrative operation. This section analyzes the operational machinery of the colonial boomerang as it was deployed in the Marmara region, tracing how techniques of counterinsurgency, dispossession, and physical terror migrated from the imperial frontiers back to the political center. Before a population's property, labor, and persons could be appropriated, the state first had to render that population expropriable: incapable of organizing resistance, incapable of self-defense, and incapable of protecting what it owned. That operation followed a clear causal sequence: remove leadership, isolate the population, disarm it, and only then extract its wealth. This section reconstructs that sequence step by step, in three distinct but historically entangled moments — the arrival of specialized perpetrators carrying frontier-tested repertoires of violence, a highly ritualized campaign of staged disarmament that functioned as a fiscal instrument of plunder, and the final transition to a coerced marketplace designed to strip the community of its remaining resources under radical duress.

Removing leadership

The first stage was the targeted removal of Armenian intellectual and communal leadership. The arrests of April 24, 1915, in Constantinople, which targeted Armenian intellectuals, clergy, and political leaders, established a pattern reproduced in the provinces: arrest, removal from the community, deportation under guard to the interior, and execution beyond public scrutiny. Bardizag's leaders were subjected to this same process. Among those arrested were Dr. Der Stepanian, the teacher Karnig Bodourian, Boghos Kourouyian, and Mihran Der-Garabedian. They were removed from the community under military guard and deported to remote locations in the

Anatolian interior, including the high-security prison at Ayas.¹⁰

Their removal did more than eliminate individual leaders. It severed Bardizag from the networks of authority and knowledge through which the community organized itself. The absence of bodies, graves, and official acknowledgment then transformed their deaths into permanent disappearances. As Özgür Sevgi Göral's work on state-sponsored disappearance demonstrates, this uncertainty can itself function as a mechanism of domination: by withholding knowledge of a victim's fate, the state extends violence beyond the act of killing, suspending families and communities between mourning and hope.¹¹ In Bardizag, the disappearance of communal leaders therefore operated both materially and psychologically, weakening the community's capacity to organize while generating fear and uncertainty among those who remained. The distance between arrest and execution was consequently not merely logistical: by transporting leaders to remote sites, the state deprived their communities of witnesses, obscured the circumstances of their deaths, and disrupted conventional practices of mourning. Disappearance thus became part of the process of communal destruction rather than simply a means of concealing violence after the fact. This disappearance had a long postwar afterlife of its own; for families who spent years trying to learn what had happened to the missing, which is taken up in Section VI, alongside the other institutional afterlives of the genocide.

Staged disarmament

According to Turkish nationalist historiography, claims that the deportations of Armenians during World War I were defensive and necessary measures taken to preserve the security of the

¹⁰ Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute.

¹¹ This episode may be understood through Özgür Sevgi Göral's analysis of enforced disappearance in Kurdistan during 1990s, which highlights the deliberate production of uncertainty regarding victims' fates as a mechanism of political violence. Viewed through this lens, Armenian Genocide was not only a history of mass killing and deportation but also a regime of disappearance in which families were denied knowledge about their loved ones. Özgür Sevgi Göral, "Waiting for the disappeared: waiting as a form of resilience and the limits of legal space in Turkey.," *Soc Anthropol*, 29, 2021, 800-815. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1469-8676.13096>

Ottoman Empire. From this perspective, the Ottomans authorities faced a dual threat: an advancing Russian army on the eastern front and internal unrest allegedly instigated by Armenian revolutionary groups such as the Dashnaks (*Dashnaktsutyun*) committees. Advocates of this view argue that Armenians in regions like İzmit, Adapazarı, and the eastern provinces engaged in espionage, rebellion, and armed collaboration with Russia, thereby endangering the stability of the state.¹² Consequently, the government is portrayed as having implemented the relocations (*tehcir*) as a precautionary response to treason and civil disorder rather than as a campaign of persecution.

The mutesarraf of İzmit, Deli Mazhar Bey (June 1913–September 1916), dutifully executed Istanbul’s orders, and by early 1915 only a few Armenian notables had been arrested—acts still seen locally as isolated repression. The turning point came with the arrival of two CUP delegates, Ibrahim Bey, former director of Istanbul’s prisons, and Hoca Rifat Effendi. Their mission was to implement mass deportation. On 5/18 July 1915, the interior ministry authorized the expulsion of Armenians from forty-two localities in the İzmit district. This directive was prepared by two months of coordinated measures: the confiscation of arms, which criminalized Armenians and provided legal cover for mass arrests, and propaganda campaigns that framed them as an existential threat.

As officers of the *Teşkilat-ı Mahsusa* (Special Organization), Ibrahim Bey and Hoca Rifat directed çete bands under Şevket Bey, Faik Bey (İzmit’s gendarmerie commander), Çeteci Mehmed, Çeteci Edhem, Çeteci Pehlivan, and Hasan Çavuş to carry out the violence on the ground. The “legal” machinery was managed by Major Mustafa Emir, Eşref Adil Bey, Beha Bey,

¹² Selma Cetinkaya and Taner Bilgin, “Tehcir Kanunu ve İzmit Ermenileri,” *Uluslararası Kara Mürsel Alp ve Kocaeli Tarihi Sempozyumu -II = International Symposium on Kara Mürsel Alp & History of Kocaeli -II*. (Kocaeli: Kocaeli Büyükşehir Belediyesi, Kültür ve Sosyal İşler Dairesi Başkanlığı Yayınları, 2016), p.1313. Ari Şekeryan, 2023. *The Armenians and the Fall of the Ottoman Empire : After Genocide, 1918-1923*. Cambridge, United Kingdom: Cambridge University Press, 2023, p.44.

militia head Hüseyin Çavuş, and police chief Reşid Bey, while İzmit's Unionist elites—naval officer İsmail Ali Bey, lawyer Şerif Bey, and pharmacist Cavid—organized propaganda and orchestrated the expropriation of Armenian assets through the emval-i metruke (abandoned property) commission.

This structure amounted to a coordinated apparatus of state and paramilitary collaboration: the Special Organization providing the instruments of terror, the civil and military bureaucracy supplying administrative legitimacy, and local Unionists ensuring the systematic transfer of Armenian property. The first deportations struck Adapazarı rather than İzmit itself. In early May, some fifty leading Armenians were arrested and sent to Sultaniye (Konya province) and Koçhisar. Soon afterward, two Ottoman divisions occupied Armenian neighborhoods—not to maintain order, but to clear the ground for destruction.

In late May 1915, the CUP delegate İbrahim Bey, a former *çete* leader from Macedonia who would later oversee atrocities in Bardizag, arrived in Adabazar and immediately ordered the arrest of prominent Armenians, including merchant Bedros Afeyan, banker Bedros Muradian, and municipal president Stepan Demirjian.¹³ Accompanied by police chief Reşid Bey, he visited the detainees confined in the Church of the Holy Archangel, boasting of his experience in raids and demanding the surrender of 250 Mauser rifles. This fabricated weapons search provided the pretext for mass arrests: within days, 600–700 men were imprisoned in the Church of St. Garabed. Under İbrahim's orders, Father Mikayel Yeramian and Antranig Charkejian were tortured for confessions about hidden arms, and ten leading figures were sent to Istanbul for trial.

On 11 August, the deportation order for Adabazar and surrounding villages was announced. Armenian neighborhoods were sealed off, escape barred, and possessions confiscated. Over the

¹³ Raymond Kevorkian, *Armenian Genocide*, p.552-555.

following two weeks, more than 20,000 Armenians; beginning with residents of Nemçer and Malacılar—were deported toward Konya. Only twenty-five families employed by the army and a single family that converted to Islam were allowed to remain. In the kaza of Ismit, the violence centered on Bardizag and Arslanbeg, targeted for evacuation before other Armenian communities. In Arslanbeg, arrests began in May; detainees were held in Ismit and then transferred to Geyve's Turkish village of Taraklı, where elites from other towns were concentrated. On 18 July, İbrahim Bey ordered 200 soldiers and gendarmes to surround Arslanbeg, after which deportations began and Çerkez çetes of the Special Organization, aided by local Turkish villagers, looted and destroyed the town. Over 2,000 people were deported via Eskişehir, Konya, and Bozanti to destinations including Rakka, Meskene, Der Zor, Mosul, and Baghdad; few returned.

With leadership removed, the operational machinery turned to disarmament. On June 27, 1915, İbrahim Bey and Ali Şuuri Bey orchestrated a staged, highly public disarmament campaign in Bardizag. This campaign involved ritualized threats of massacre and the systematic conversion of civic and religious institutions; village schools and churches into militarized spaces of coercion. The primary physical technology of this coercion was the *falaka*, ritualized beating on the soles of the feet, administered by İbrahim Bey and his gang of irregulars. The *falaka* was not merely an instrument of physical punishment; it functioned as a fiscal instrument designed to break communal resistance, enforce submission, and facilitate mass plunder. By subjecting community leaders and ordinary residents to systematic violence, state officials forced the population to reveal hidden weapon caches, gold, and personal valuables.

The postwar Izmit deportation trial testimonies provide rich empirical evidence of this ritualized violence. Kirkor Efendi, a janitor at the Armenian patriarchate, testified that when they were sent to Izmit, they were imprisoned inside a church, where he was beaten with a falaka in the

direct presence of İbrahim Bey, who then confiscated his money. Mıgırdıç testified that during his transfer from Istanbul to Çankırı, he was detained for five days in İzmit, taken to a house where İbrahim Bey was staying, and severely beaten. Artin Kürekçiyan and Karabet from İzmit both testified that İbrahim Bey imprisoned groups of Armenians and ordered his gendarmes to beat them. Serope Efendi confirmed that during her transfer to Konya via İzmit, she witnessed and heard that İbrahim Bey's entourage systematically beat deportees and took their money. Hacı Mıgırdıç Karabet testified that İbrahim Bey arrived to collect weapons fifteen days prior to the deportation, mistreating the inhabitants in every possible way, while Ali Şuuri Bey accompanied him and directly seized personal belongings from his house. Priest Aganya Efendi of Bardizag and Minas Efendi likewise confirmed that İbrahim Bey assaulted the villagers under the pretext of weapon collection.

This violence culminated in the partial demolition of the village church during extensive searches. After repeated rounds of torture with wet canes, surviving community leaders were forced to sign documents pledging to surrender any remaining arms under penalty of immediate death. Gendarmes then conducted exhaustive house-to-house sweeps of every household, khan, and local silk-spinning factory, confiscating not only firearms but also any metal tool that could potentially be used for defense, including pocketknives, saws, and agricultural sickles. This performative act of selective dispossession was highly asymmetrical: while weapons were permanently stripped from Armenians, those surrendered by neighboring Muslim villagers were promptly returned to them. That asymmetry is not incidental, and it is not merely an anecdote. It demonstrates that “disarmament” was not neutral security policy: it dismantled Armenian collective capacity while preserving the coercive capacity of the population that would benefit from Armenian dispossession. The causal sequence is worth stating explicitly, because it is easy for a reader to miss if it is left implicit: remove leadership, isolate the population, disarm the

population, thereby make resistance difficult, and thereby facilitate expropriation. By leaving Armenians entirely defenseless while arming surrounding populations, the state produced the specific vulnerability required to execute the final stage of primitive accumulation; the liquidation of the community's remaining wealth.

The coerced marketplace

Once the community was stripped of its leadership and defensive capacity, the operational machinery shifted from physical terror to administrative and financial extraction. This transition was designed to liquidate the remaining portable wealth of the Armenian population and transfer it into the hands of state officials, CUP networks, and neighboring Muslim populations. Before the formal deportation order was issued, the state utilized administrative fraud and extortion to drain the community's financial reserves, exploiting survivors' desperate hope for safety. Hagop der Hagopian recorded that Bardizag's villagers collectively raised four hundred gold liras as a donation for the Ottoman Red Crescent and military hospital, presenting it to local governor Ali Şuuri Bey in a desperate attempt to demonstrate civic compliance and purchase safety.¹⁴ While the donation was accepted and praised by the authorities, it offered no protection against subsequent dispossession. On an individual level, families were forced to pay extortionate bribes of up to four hundred Turkish pounds under the false administrative promise that such payments would exempt them from the deportation lists. Ali Şuuri Bey also used his direct administrative authority for personal corruption: during the postwar trials, the merchant Mihran Semerciyan testified that Ali Şuuri Bey had engaged in rampant corruption during the deportations, extorting 650 liras worth of his personal belongings under direct threat.

¹⁴ Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute. p.x.

The resulting scene in the streets of Bardizag is best conceptualized as a coerced marketplace, rather than a merely “distressed” economic space. Under ordinary market logic, prices fluctuate according to supply and demand. Here, exchange was dictated by radical asymmetry, duress, and extra-economic coercion. Crowds of neighboring Muslim populations; Laz, Georgian, Tatar, and Turkish neighbors, arrived in the village specifically to profit from the forced liquidations.¹⁵ The prices paid for Armenian assets were catastrophically low: fully furnished houses were emptied within days, with furniture, jewelry, and prized household goods worth five to ten liras sold for a mere five to ten kuruş, a fraction of a lira. Most families recovered only trivial, insulting amounts; usually no more than three, five, or ten liras, which were often immediately stolen or confiscated by gendarmerie forces on the road. Some families, recognizing this process as state-sanctioned and legalized plunder, refused to participate in the marketplace, choosing instead to face deportation with their belongings intact and preferring the risk of death to submission to systemic robbery. Whatever items remained unsold in the emptied homes were subsequently confiscated by the Abandoned Property Officer (*Emval-i Metruke*) and redistributed to loyal CUP elites or state institutions, or used to resettle Muslim refugees, fully institutionalizing the capital transfer.

This account is consistent with, and builds on, the historiography establishing that the confiscation of Armenian property was not a chaotic byproduct of wartime dislocation or localized opportunistic greed, as mainstream historiography analyzed it for decades. Pioneering research by Hilmar Kaiser, Ümit Kurt, and Bedross Der Matossian has demonstrated instead that the confiscation of Armenian properties was orchestrated through the full administrative and legislative machinery of the Ottoman state, bridging central ministries with provincial and local authorities. This vast, state-led bureaucratic apparatus targeted private, communal, and ecclesiastical assets alike, utilizing legislative codes such as the Temporary Law of Expropriation

¹⁵ *Ibid.*

and Confiscation of September 13, 1915, to systematically liquidate and redistribute Armenian wealth. In his critical analysis of genocidal violence, Yektan Türkyılmaz draws on Claudia Card's concept of "social death" to argue that the Armenian Genocide did not merely target biological life but aimed at the absolute destruction of Western Armenian social, political, cultural, and economic networks; the systematic transfer of capital served as the primary instrument of this social death.¹⁶ As Harry Harootunian has argued, the genocide was a large-scale project of primitive accumulation through which pre-capitalist wealth, generated through centuries of Armenian labor, agriculture, and commerce, was forcefully converted into the foundational capital essential for the emerging Turkish national economy.¹⁷ In Bardizag, this took a highly physical and localized form: as missionary Arthur Ryan reported, in the wake of the August 1915 deportations movable Armenian property was systematically gathered by Ottoman officials and shipped to Istanbul, while sixty Muslim families were immediately settled in the vacated Armenian homes. Through this process of legal and extra-legal redistribution, the newly founded Turkish Republic positioned itself as the direct heir to the confiscated wealth. By redistributing these assets to members of the Committee of Union and Progress, local Muslim elites, and loyal businessmen, the state actively restructured class relations, consolidating a compliant and dependent Turkish national bourgeoisie whose class survival was structurally tethered to the erasure of the Armenian presence.

The techniques of dispossession and extraction deployed in the streets of Bardizag; forced liquidation, administrative fraud, extortion, and the mobilization of neighboring ethnic communities as instruments of dispossession, were not novel. They represented a highly coordinated form of the fiscal instrument that had already been practiced on the empire's populations for decades. In 1915, the colonial boomerang returned to the heartland, converting the wealth generated through centuries of Armenian labor into foundational capital for the emerging

¹⁶ Yektan Türkyılmaz, p.337.

¹⁷ Harry Harootunian

national economy.

III. The Gendered Forms of Expropriation

Expropriation in Bardizag was gendered from the beginning, not merely in its consequences but in its mechanisms. The genocidal economy assigned Armenian bodies different forms of extractive value according to gender and age: men's labor was conscripted into the state's logistical apparatus arrest, conscription, labor battalions, later military factories, productive labor, while women and children were absorbed into households, captivity, domestic labor, forced incorporation, marriage, reproductive and care work, household production. This was not a secondary effect of a gender-neutral process of destruction; it was one of the primary mechanisms through which destruction was converted into accumulation. The point is not simply that women were also victims. It is that the genocidal economy assigned Armenian bodies different forms of extractive value according to gender and age.

Men: conscription and labor battalions

With the onset of mobilization, the Ottoman state conscripted nearly all of Bardizag's young men, approximately one thousand individuals, into auxiliary, unarmed labor battalions (*amele taburlari*) in May 1915.¹⁸ In August, nineteen-year-old conscripts were also drafted and transferred to Constantinople. Reflecting the state's deep structural mistrust of its Christian subjects, these men were kept entirely unarmed and assigned to grueling logistical tasks: road construction, railway repair, agricultural labor, and the transportation of military provisions over long distances on foot. Lacking basic shelter, clothing, and adequate food, these conscripts endured extreme suffering in what survivors called "camps of shadows," where their bodies were ravaged by

¹⁸ Tigran Martirosyan, "Labour Battalions: Ottoman Empire/Middle East," 1914-1918 International Encyclopedia of the First World War," <https://encyclopedia.1914-1918-online.net/article/labour-battalions-ottoman-empiremiddle-east/> (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

disease, starvation, and exposure. By draining Bardizag of its young, able-bodied male population, the Ottoman state effectively eliminated the possibility of armed resistance and initiated the economic devaluation of Armenian labor; productive labor extracted from men under conditions designed to exhaust rather than sustain them.

Women and children: a conceptual framework

For women and children, expropriation operated differently: not through conscription into state labor but through household captivity. Three concepts, developed more fully in Section IV through the case of Arshalous Patoogian, describe how this worked. Recursive expropriation treats expropriation not as a single originary act but as a repeating, serial structure. A captive sold and resold across successive households had the relation of domination reset with each transfer, stripping away whatever relational capital, local knowledge, and fragile social ties she had begun to accumulate, and foreclosing the possibility of escape.

Coerced incorporation describes captives' absorption into intimate household categories — wife, maid, rescued orphan, protected person. These legible classifications naturalized their dependency and co-opted social structures to obscure what was, in substance, an unfree and unwaged labor relation. Domination, in other words, does not always operate by keeping someone visibly outside society; sometimes it works by absorbing them into social categories that conceal coercion, making it harder to see.

Hollow freedom names the colonization of respected legal and social forms, most notably the legal registration of marriage (*pasakadrutyun*). It describes a condition in which a formal or socially recognized status associated with consent; particularly marriage exists without the material conditions necessary for meaningful choice. As exemplified by Taguhi Seferian-Antonyan, known as Hikmet Hanım after her marriage to Ali Şuuri Bey, ordinary institutions were

co-opted as instruments of possession, rendering captivity invisible while demanding total identity renunciation as the price of physical survival.¹⁹

Racial capitalism

By focusing on the extraction of human capacity, this chapter enters into dialogue with Black radical feminist scholarship and theories of racial capitalism, which insist that capitalist relations have always depended on a relational, racialized, gendered division of labor: the formal freedom of the favored population is relationally distributed across unequal social fields and remains structurally dependent upon the violent, unfree subjection of others. Saidiya Hartman's analysis in *Scenes of Subjection* is useful for elaborating this dynamic, but it must be used carefully; as a conceptual tool, not as an equivalence between the Ottoman Armenian case and the history of African American enslavement. Hartman demonstrates that the U.S. postbellum order reconciled freedom and bondage within the grammar of liberal legality: the state legally recognized formerly enslaved Black subjects in order to discipline and manage them through contract law and new legal codes. In the American case, the master-slave dynamic was codified, and its violence was subsequently administered through the very institutions of freedom; contract, wage, juridical personhood, that nominally superseded it.²⁰ Even after emancipation, Black subjects remained visible to the law as subjects whose freedom required management; bondage and liberty were not oppositional categories but were reconciled within the grammar of liberal legality itself. Hartman's intervention thus fundamentally reframes the relationship between freedom and domination: the production of free subjects has historically depended upon expropriative relations that remain structurally obscured.

The Armenian case both confirms Hartman's insight into freedom's constitutive dependence

¹⁹ Katharine Derderian, "Common Fate, Different Experience: Gender-specific Aspects of the Armenian Genocide, 1915-1917," *Holocaust Genocide Studies*. Vol.19, N.1, p.12.

²⁰ Saidiya Hartman, *Scenes of Subjection: Terror, Slavery and Self-Making in the Nineteenth Century America*, p.X.

on unfreedom and demands a crucial analytical extension. Unlike the postbellum American context, the late Ottoman domestic space in which Armenian women and children were held captive operated through a regime this chapter calls juridical disappearance, which persisted until the Armistice of Mudros. There were no Ottoman slave codes naming the condition of a captive Armenian woman or child, no formal emancipation to be administered, and no legal category through which her captivity could become publicly legible or contestable. In the absence of slave codes, the captivity of Armenian women and children was rendered legally and socially invisible. The Ottoman state did not manage the captive through legal recognition; instead, it actively inverted the violence of captivity through the naturalizing, benevolent languages of “rescue,” charity, and domestic kinship; she was framed not as enslaved but as rescued, saved from genocide, charitably integrated into Muslim domestic life through the language of protection. This distinction is historically significant because it reveals a different modality of expropriative power. If Hartman demonstrates how domination survived through juridical recognition, the Armenian case demonstrates how domination could persist through juridical disappearance. Rather than reconciling freedom and bondage through law, Ottoman domestic structures dissolved the contradiction by rendering bondage socially invisible until, that is, the collapse of the CUP regime and the Allied occupation finally forced an acknowledgment. Following the end of the First World War, the Ministry of Interior of the new Ottoman government, acting under orders from the Allied forces, issued directives beginning in November 1918 for the release of Armenian slaves, political prisoners, orphan girls, and women, as Nazan Maksudyan has shown.²¹ Lerna Ekmekcioglu has also shown that the Ministry’s directive specifically addressed the detention of Armenian women and children, explicitly acknowledging their status as “slaves,” and instructed that Christian girls and children who had been kept by force (*cebren*) in Muslim households be freed and returned to

²¹ Nazan Maksudyan, *Ottoman Children and Youth During World War One*, p.114.

their relatives, or handed over to local Armenian religious authorities — an acknowledgment that arrived only after the fact, and only under Allied pressure.²²

It is worth being precise about the vocabulary this chapter uses for that condition. Forced labor, or unfree labor, describes any form of work performed against a person's will (*cebren*), under the constant threat of death, violence, detention, destitution, or other extreme hardship affecting the person or their family, relatives, or community. Slavery is often distinguished from this by the fact that the enslaved person's place of work and residence is dictated by whoever holds them in bondage, such that the person is treated as the property of an owner. The Armenian women and children of Bardizag experienced both registers simultaneously, which is precisely why the Ottoman state's refusal to name their condition in law — until the very end of the war — mattered so much: it was not simply a legal oversight but an active, sustained mechanism of concealment.

A constitutive silence

Holding these gendered sites of extraction together in a single analytical frame exposes what might be called a constitutive silence in Ottoman labor and gender historiography. Ezgi Akyol's recent work powerfully reframes the First World War as a process of "total destruction," arguing that wartime capitalism transformed Ottoman society far beyond the Armenian case alone: faced with bankruptcy and the demands of total war, the empire mobilized women and children into the war economy, accelerating processes of primitive accumulation, proletarianization, and social dislocation.²³ Small producers lost autonomy, rural populations were uprooted, and wartime economic pressures drove mass movement into urban labor structures. Recent scholarship has

²² Lerna Ekmekçioğlu, "A Climate for Abduction," p.533.

²³ Ezgi Akyol, *Birinci Dünya Savaşı'nda Osmanlı İmparatorluğu'nda İlkel Birikim ve Kapitalist Devlet*. Unpublished PhD Dissertation (İstanbul Üniversitesi, Siyasal Bilgiler Fakültesi, Kamu Yönetimi Ve Siyaset Bilimi Bölümü, İstanbul, 2022).

extensively documented this wartime mobilization of Muslim women into public workshops and state agencies such as the Islamic Organization for the Employment of Women. It remains silent, however, on the simultaneous, genocidal domestic captivity of Armenian women. This chapter's account of Akyol's framework is not a rejection of it; total war did reorganize Ottoman society at every level; but an insistence that even within this expansive framework, Armenian women and children remain largely absent. The category of wartime labor mobilization has been analyzed without sustained attention to the fact that another population was simultaneously being transformed into expropriated and captive labor through genocidal violence.

Patriotic labor mobilization and genocidal domestic captivity were, this chapter argues, two sides of the exact same wartime political economy. The unfree, unwaged domestic labor of Armenian women and children, alongside the unfree labor of the male "productive remnant" conscripted into labor battalions and, later, Cemal Pasha's military factories in Syria, served as the hidden precondition for the social reproduction and relative freedom of the favored population in the emerging national order. The micro-history of Bardizag thus reveals that the Armenian Genocide was not merely a project of physical elimination: by mobilizing the full administrative, military, and legal machinery of the state, the Ottoman government converted the destruction of a proximate community into a self-renewing engine of capital accumulation, class restructuring, and national consolidation that outlived the empire itself.

IV. Recursive Expropriation: Arshalous Patoogian

The archives of the Ottoman Ministry of Interior are filled with documents recording such "adoptions." The Directorate of Public Security explicitly stated that the state had no objection to officials adopting Armenian girls. In practice, these policies were carried out on a massive scale. According to the personal registers of Talat Pasha, as later published by Murat Bardakçı, out

of 10,314 Armenian orphans reported by provincial authorities, 6,858 were distributed to Muslim families, while 3,456 were placed in state orphanages.²⁴ These figures, while incomplete, underscore the institutionalized character of child expropriation; what might be termed the bureaucratization of abduction, a process through which the Ottoman state transformed Armenian children into objects of demographic engineering and social assimilation. Hundreds of additional children were later transferred from Anatolia to Istanbul through the Islamic Society for the Employment of Women (*Kadınları Çalıştırma Cemiyet-i İslamiyesi*). Girls were distributed to Muslim households chosen by the Ministry, and boys were sent to workshops and small businesses, blurring the lines between humanitarian welfare, forced labor, and cultural

9

No	Name and Surname	Father's Name	Mother's Name	Native Country	Age	Admission date
1307	Arshalous Patoogian	Magratish	Armenouhi	Bardizag Constantinople	30	5 May 1924



Arshalous was deported from Bardizag with her parents and a little brother. They suffered awfully on the road, and when the caravan reached Meskene her parents died from starvation and disease.

erasure. (transition needed here)

The concepts developed above — recursive expropriation, coerced incorporation, hollow freedom — are not abstractions. They describe the actual trajectory of one Bardizag woman, Arshalous Patoogian, whose case runs through the rest of this chapter as its human thread. Her

²⁴ Murat Bardakçı, *Talât Paşa'nın Evrak-ı Metrukesi*, p.88–89. Fuat Dündar, *Modern Türkiye'nin Şifresi*, 30; Watenpaugh, "The League of Nations' Rescue," 1329.

story is not presented here as an uncomplicated tale of survival: her testimony was mediated by humanitarian institutions, and this section treats that mediation with methodological care rather than treating her as a straightforward witness to her own past. Born and raised in Bardizag, Arshalous was deported with her parents and younger brother in August 1915.²⁵ By the time the caravan reached Meskene, her parents had died of starvation and disease. Her brother was taken by an Arab man, and Arshalous, now orphaned, was seized into captivity.

What followed was not a single act of expropriation but a recursive one. She was sold and resold across households, each transfer resetting the relation of domination under new hands and conditions. After two years with her first captor, she was sold again; mistreated, she attempted to flee, but was recaptured at Deir ez-Zor by a man named Abou Djmeyd and compelled into a five-year forced marriage with one of his relatives. Each sale broke her social connections, changed who controlled her labor, destroyed accumulated local knowledge, and reset her vulnerability — converting her again into an object of exchange. The captive market she moved through was not incidental to her subjection but its sustaining mechanism: no site of captivity ever became familiar enough to be navigated toward escape.

Marriage as hollow freedom

The forced marriage crystallizes this dynamic with clarity. Her earlier captivities operated through direct, visible force; marriage instead appropriated one of the central institutions through which societies reproduce free subjects, subjecting her through a juridical form ordinarily associated with consent. Domination here did not operate outside the law but through it: she entered the household not as a subject requiring management, but as a wife — dependent, and

²⁵ C1603-499-1101-1200, No:1121, Armenian Orphanage Aleppo of Registry of Inmates. <https://archives.ungeneva.org/challenge-inline?url=/armenian-orphanage-aleppo-registry-of-inmates-n-1-100> (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

simultaneously cast as a beneficiary of rescue. Unlike the postbellum U.S. order Hartman analyzes, where law named and disciplined the subject it claimed to free, Ottoman domestic institutions absorbed Arshalous without ever recognizing her captivity as such. What remained constant across her captivities, from informal seizure to juridically formalized marriage, was not their legal character but their structural function: the conversion of her person into a resource, her labor into unwaged service, her unfreedom into the condition of others' relative freedom.

Her case suggests an afterlife of genocide analogous to what Hartman calls slavery's afterlife: expropriation survived mass death by reorganizing itself within domestic institutions and kinship structures rather than disappearing with it. When escape finally came, it depended not on the restoration of any right but on external intervention; Armenian rescue agents in Syria facilitated her removal to the orphanage run by Karen Jeppe, from where relatives in Greece attempted to reclaim her. Arshalous's case confirms Fraser's insight that freedom is not a condition individuals simply possess but one distributed unevenly across a social field, underwritten by others' confiscation; it also demands an additional category beyond Hartman's: an expropriative power that operates not through the legal codification of bondage, nor through the disciplinary management of emancipation, but through the active concealment of domination within the ordinary institutions of domestic freedom itself.

Arshalous's testimony survives within the humanitarian archive created by the Danish relief worker Karen Jeppe, who established the Reception Home in Aleppo in 1921 to locate, identify, and where possible reunite Armenians absorbed into Muslim households.²⁶ Rescued Armenians received a medical exam and were entered into a register, each given a number, along with whatever remained of their name, their parents, birthplace, remembered relatives, and account of

²⁶ Matthias Bjørnlund & Elyse Semerdjian, "Karen Jeppe (1876-1935): 'Mother of Armenians'," Houshamadyan, <https://www.houshamadyan.org/mapottomanempire/vilayetaleppo/sandjak-of-aleppo/religion/missionaries.html> (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

captivity, with a photograph attached, so they could be matched with relatives searching for them as far away as Europe or the United States. This provenance matters. Arshalous's testimony is not an unmediated transcript of her past but an artifact of a rescue institution's documentary purpose: Jeppe's staff needed to establish who a survivor was and whether she could be identified and reunited, so her testimony functioned simultaneously as personal narrative and as an instrument of identification. That context does not diminish its value; it deepens it, because the register is itself evidence of a historical reversal. During the genocide, women like Arshalous were rendered administratively disposable: deported, separated from relatives, renamed, absorbed into households in ways that obscured who they had been. At the Reception Home, the same documentary techniques were redeployed to make an individual legible again. Read this way, Arshalous's case shows that recursive expropriation had an archival dimension as well as an economic one: where the household sought to incorporate her by suppressing her previous identity, the humanitarian archive sought to make that identity recoverable. The full institutional consequences of this contrast; a genocidal administration that made Armenians disappear from the record, set against a humanitarian one that worked to make them legible again are taken up further in Section VI.

(transition needed here). Edita Gzoyan and Regina Galustyan examined 1,464 intake files of rescued Armenian women and children archived by the League of Nations. In their article, *Forced Marriages as a Tool of Genocide: The Armenian Case*, the authors reveal that 577 of these files document women; most of whom were subjected to sexual violence.²⁷ The interviews consistently point to a systematic pattern of genocide, including deportations, massacres, rape, enslavement, and forced marriage. Nearly half of the files concerning rescued women (238 in total) referenced coerced marriages to Muslim men—Turks, Kurds, Arabs, Chechens, and

²⁷ Edita Gzoyan and Regina Galustyan, "Forced Marriages as a Tool of Genocide: the Armenian Case," *The International Journal of Human Rights*, Vol.25, no. 10, p.X

others. These marriages often involved girls as young as nine or ten, while some husbands were as old as sixty. In many cases, girls were initially adopted and later sold, married off, or married by their adoptive “guardians,”. Some files even describe situations where mothers and daughters or sisters were forced to marry the same man. Others were taken into harems.

V. Deportation as Relocation, Not Termination

As the deportations of August 13–15, 1915, emptied the homes, vineyards, and workshops of Bardizag, the primary phase of genocidal destruction and material confiscation appeared complete. The Armenian community’s material world had been dismantled, and its surviving members were driven down the forced routes toward the Syrian desert. However, the political economy of the Armenian Genocide did not conclude with the physical seizure of property and the removal of bodies from the Marmara region. Deportation did not end the extraction of Armenian labor; it relocated it. As the survivors of Bardizag, Adapazarı, and other provincial towns crossed into the southern and eastern frontiers of the empire, they were subjected to a new phase of extraction, organized by the same administrative logic that had dismantled their communities at home, now redeployed in the transit camps, desert outposts, and state factories of Syria. Here, the Committee of Union and Progress state engineered a system that reorganized the “productive remnant” of the Armenian population: the surviving bodies and technical skills of Armenian artisans were conscripted into military provisioning, converting survivors into unfree, unwaged producers for the very state apparatus that had destroyed their families and communities.

A weaponized landscape

To understand the specific vulnerability that enabled the extraction of unfree Armenian labor in Syria, it is worth first considering the environmental conditions of the deportation itself. As survivors left the Marmara region, they were thrust into an environment deliberately mobilized as

an instrument of state violence. In his exploration of the environmental history of the genocide, Samuel Dolbee demonstrates how the state utilized the desert's climate and geography as an active tool of killing and concealment, maintaining a veneer of natural inevitability over what was a highly calculated state program. Drawing on Elyse Semerdjian's concept of the "weaponized environment," Dolbee argues that Ottoman authorities did not merely deport Armenians to the desert; they enlisted the desert itself; its extreme heat and endemic diseases, as nonhuman agents to perform the "dirty work" of mass execution while preserving state deniability.²⁸

For the deportees of Bardizag, the journey through the Syrian desert consumed everything. Arshalous Patoogian's parents died of starvation and disease before their caravan even reached Meskene, leaving her orphaned and entirely defenseless. Other survivors, such as Abraham Aghbasian of Tomarza, Kayseri, record the desperate measures required to sustain physical existence in this weaponized landscape: foraging for wild dandelions, drinking rainwater, and a constant search for sustenance in inhospitable terrain that frequently resulted in accidental poisoning and death — underscoring the absolute material deprivation endured by deportees.²⁹ As Jason De León argues in his study of state-engineered border violence, nonhuman agents mask human responsibility, transforming political crimes into natural tragedies. The state-sponsored attack on Armenian communal solidarity and infrastructure, the intentional withholding of food and water, and the stripping of deportees' tools reduced Bardizag's Armenian population to something approaching Agamben's "bare life," creating a condition of absolute dependency.³⁰ By the time surviving remnants of Bardizag reached the transit camps of northern Syria, their survival was entirely contingent on the arbitrary decisions of state officials. This environmental dimension is best understood as evidence of how the state's violence was administered — the specific

²⁸ Samuel Dolbee, "The Desert at the End of Empire: An Environmental History of the Armenian Genocide," *Past & Present*, Volume 247, Issue 1, May 2020, p.198-202.

²⁹ Hasmik Grigoryan, "Food Procurement Methods During the Armenian Genocide as Expressions of "Unarmed Resistance: Children's Experiences," p.49.

³⁰ Giorgio Agamben, *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life*. Stanford University Press, 1998.

mechanism that stripped survivors of any remaining leverage — rather than as a separate theoretical pillar in its own right; what it produced, materially, was a population with nothing left to bargain with, and it was under exactly these conditions of vulnerability that Cemal Pasha, commander of the Ottoman Fourth Army and governor of Syria, implemented a distinct policy of labor mobilization functioning as a biopolitical labor regime.

Artisan permits and Cemal Pasha's factories

For the deportees of western Anatolia, the city of Aleppo and its surrounding environment represented the primary node of the genocidal administrative network. When the journalist Yervant Odian reached Sebil, a vast, barren plain lying east of Aleppo, he entered what survivors would later call “the gateway to hell.”³¹ Sebil functioned as a massive, open-air transit camp where thousands of deportees from Bardizag, Adapazarı, Edirne, and other regions were forced to wait under the open sky, suspended between the immediate threat of further deportation to the killing fields of Deir ez-Zor and the hunger and disease around them, constructing a temporary tent city. Odian’s account of Sebil also exposes one of the most horrific dimensions of the deportation: the systematic trade and exploitation of Armenian children. He writes that he saw, for the first time, “the dreadful, heart-rending trade in children” in the camp. Arab, Turkish, and Jewish women traveled from Aleppo in carriages, going from tent to tent asking, “*Satılık çocuk var mı?*” (Are there children for sale?).³² Odian recounts witnessing a mother lose her sanity only hours after selling her two children; others sank into a state of stupor, their gaze distant, sitting silently on the ground for hours. This testimony underscores the psychological toll of enforced dispossession and the commodification of Armenian children, who were treated as objects to be bought and sold.

³¹ Yervant Odian, *Accursed Years: My Exile and Return from Der-Zor 1914-1919*. (London: Gomidas Institute, 2009), p.96.

³² *Ibid*, p.99.

In his memoirs, Karnig Bodourian, a teacher from Bardizag, confirms that many families from his home village were clustered in these tents, waiting for their fate to be decided. It was in this setting that Odian and his companions sought shelter in the tent of a Bardizag family. The head of this household revealed a crucial piece of administrative information: they had managed to arrange a transfer to Damascus, escaping the death marches to Deir ez-Zor, because Cemal Pasha had issued a decree allowing certain artisans to be separated from the main deportation convoys and sent to Damascus to work in government-run military factories.

According to this Bardizag survivor, the authorities were actively seeking tailors, shoemakers, metalworkers, carpenters, and weavers. In theory, this order provided a small window of survival for a fraction of the deported population. In practice, it established a highly coercive system of selection that reorganized Armenian productive capacity to serve the needs of the Ottoman military economy. As the Bardizag man explained to Odian, the factories established by Cemal Pasha in Aleppo and Damascus represented a new dimension of the colonial boomerang: the direct conversion of expropriated, dispossessed persons into unfree, military producers for the very state that had destroyed their communities. This labor mobilization was structurally continuous with the earlier moments of the boomerang that had dismantled Bardizag. The same state apparatus that had dispatched Ibrahim Bey to disarm the village's artisans, confiscate their tools, and deport them into the desert now found those same tailors, weavers, and carpenters useful again. This time, however, they were not independent economic agents operating within a prosperous Armenian town; they were captive, unfree laborers stripped of their tools, their mobility, and their legal protections, whose survival was entirely dependent on their continued productivity for the Ottoman military. The boomerang had not simply returned violence inward to the heartland; it returned the dispossessed labor force inward to the state's military-industrial apparatus in the Arab provinces.

Under Cemal Pasha's military administration, the Fourth Army established six major army-

run factories in Aleppo alone, alongside a similar workshop in Damascus. These factories functioned as highly extractive spaces where Armenian survivors; predominantly widows and young girls, were put to work producing clothing, tents, and bedding for the Ottoman troops. Reports from the American consul in Aleppo estimated that within just two months, these factories employed approximately 6,500 women, mostly widows, 3,000 young girls, and 650 men and older boys.³³ For this workforce of over ten thousand survivors, compensation was reduced to the barest minimum required to prevent starvation: a single loaf of bread and a bowl of soup each day. Yet under the constant threat of deportation to Deir ez-Zor, this minimal sustenance represented the difference between life and death.

This system is best read as a biopolitical labor regime. The artisan permits circulating through the transit camps of Meskene, Sebil, and Aleppo were not gestures of humanitarian mercy or inclusion; they were administrative instruments of selection. Through this permit system, the Ottoman state systematically sorted the surviving remnant of the Armenian population by its remaining extractable value. The state discarded those from whom nothing further could be taken, allowing the elderly, the sick, and the very young to perish in the desert, while conscripting those whose technical skills could be actively utilized to reduce the costs of social reproduction and military provisioning for the state. Armenian weavers who had once operated within the commercial networks of Bardizag were now forced to stitch Ottoman military uniforms to clothe the soldiers administering their dispossession. The unfree, uncompensated labor of these widows and artisans became the hidden precondition for the survival and relative freedom of the favored populations within the wartime national order. Survival under Cemal Pasha's system required complete submission to the machinery of one's own dispossession: a survivor's life was preserved only as long as their body could be converted into unfree military capital.

³³ M.Talha Cicek, *War and State Formation in Syria: Cemal Pasha's Governorate during World War I, 1914–1917* (New York: Routledge, 2014), p.96. Umit Kurt, "Life and Death from Yemen to the Euphrates: An Evaluation on Syrian Governor Cemal Pasha," *Journal of Balkan and Near Eastern Studies*, Vol.27, No.6, 2025. pp.813-833.

Manipulating the categories of selection

Confronted with this biopolitical labor regime, where the lack of an artisan permit meant certain death, Armenian survivors engaged in sophisticated tactics of deception, mimicry, and collective solidarity to subvert the state's categorization. Because the permit system established a rigid boundary between the "useful" artisan and the "disposable" deportee, survivors actively sought to blur these categories through bribery, forgery, and mutual aid. This resistance evidence matters because, left out, the chapter would risk making Armenians appear only as objects of state power; even within a highly coercive system, survivors actively manipulated the bureaucratic categories through which the state attempted to control them.

When Yervant Odian asked the Bardizag man in the Sebil camp whether all the families granted transfers to Damascus were truly skilled artisans, the man admitted frankly that many had secured their exemptions "by bribery or deception." Inside the crowded tents of Sebil, a remarkable scene unfolded: actual weavers and tailors from Bardizag spent their nights patiently teaching untrained neighbors, friends, and fellow deportees how to sew, stitch, and hold needles. Guided by their wives and skilled companions, these "artisans-in-making" hastily rehearsed the technical gestures of tailoring under the dim light of oil lamps, preparing to perform their newly claimed identities before the inspecting Ottoman officers the following morning. These fragile efforts at improvisation were profound acts of resistance, subverting the state's attempts to measure and exploit only pre-existing human capacity.

Furthermore, a shadow market in identity documents and permits emerged within the camps. Because the state kept no centralized, biometric records of the shifting mass of deportees, permits and identity cards became highly valuable, liquid assets that could be detached from their original owners. The Bardizag men eventually helped Odian's group purchase two artisan permits

belonging to deceased deportees for one Turkish lira each. Later, Odian himself acquired a *nüfus tezkiresi*, an official Ottoman identity card belonging to a recently deceased Armenian from Bardizag, paying half a lira to a camp intermediary. This document identified the cosmopolitan Constantinople journalist as “Asadour from Bardizag,” a fifty-two-year-old builder, married with two children. Though entirely false, this paper provided Odian with the protective social legibility of a “useful” builder from the Marmara, shielding him from the immediate threat of deportation. This counter-market in papers reveals a striking paradox: while the Ottoman state mobilized its bureaucratic resources to register, classify, and dispossess the Armenian population, survivors co-opted these very same bureaucratic instruments, turning the names and papers of the dead into protective shields for the living.

The contradiction of Cemal Pasha

At the center of this extractive system stood the contradictory figure of Cemal Pasha, whose wartime policies in Syria have frequently been cited by apologists to project an image of moral authority and humanitarian exceptionalism. Publicly, Cemal Pasha declared that the Ottoman military authorities bore full responsibility for the “life, honor, and well-being” of all Armenians under their jurisdiction. He went so far as to order the public execution of a gendarmerie officer accused of mistreating Armenian refugees, a performance designed to signal his commitment to justice and distance himself from the overt violence of Talat and Enver in Istanbul.

However, analyzing his policies through the lens of political economy reveals that this “protection” was deeply embedded within the broader machinery of genocidal displacement and control. The six army-run factories in Aleppo and the workshops of Damascus were not acts of altruism; they were highly organized, state-administered sweatshops designed to exploit a captive, desperate, and completely dispossessed population. By providing a minimal, sub-subsistence

ration of a single loaf of bread and a bowl of soup, Cemal Pasha managed to keep a workforce of over ten thousand women and children alive while extracting their labor at zero wage cost to the Ottoman state. This was not a departure from the logic of primitive accumulation established in Bardizag but its ultimate institutionalization. The Fourth Army systematically capitalized on the destruction of Armenian independent economic life, converting the survival instinct of the “productive remnant” into a highly efficient military-industrial asset. As Nancy Fraser argues, the relative security of those within the recognized political community is materially underwritten by the violent, uncompensated confiscation of the racialized, excluded subject. In Cemal Pasha’s Syria, this relationship was laid bare: the survival of the Ottoman military apparatus on the southern front was stitched together by the unfree, uncompensated labor of Armenian widows and children, whose independent social reproduction had first been thoroughly annihilated by the state.

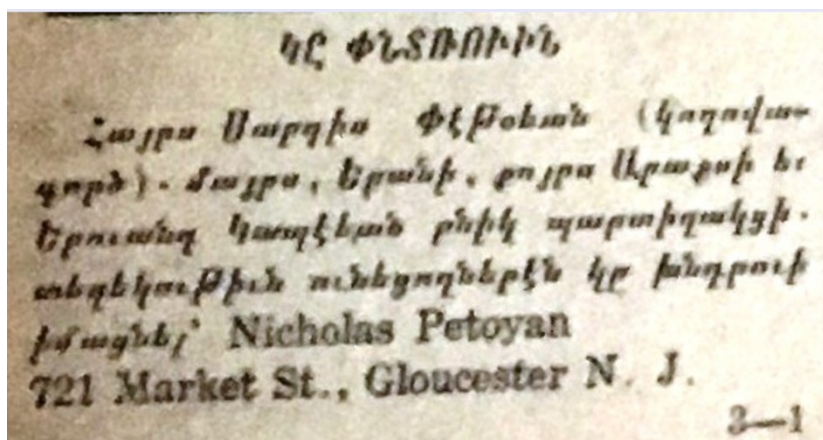
VI. Afterlives of Expropriation

Expropriation in Bardizag did not end with deportation, and it did not end with the war. It persisted in the social destruction wrought by unresolved disappearance, in the postwar institutions that attempted, imperfectly, to reverse that destruction, and in the political and material continuities that carried individual perpetrators and confiscated property forward into the Turkish Republic.

Disappearance, as a category of violence, is not merely incidental to genocide; it constitutes a deliberate tactic designed to terrorize communities, eliminate leadership, and obstruct the possibility of mourning and justice. It describes how state apparatuses or irregular units, often at the state’s encouragement, cause individuals to vanish; whether in official state spaces such as police stations and detention centers, or in remote locations beyond public visibility, such as deep forests or desolate interior regions; such that their fate remains denied and unacknowledged. When

carried out with genocidal intent, disappearance becomes a constitutive act of genocide itself, and Bardizag demonstrates this at every stage, from the arrest of communal leaders in Section II to the fate of families deported into Syria in Section V.

This process continued long after the deportations themselves. Following the First World War and the collapse of the CUP regime, survivors scattered across the globe struggled to establish the fate of relatives who had disappeared during the genocide. Armenian-language newspapers such as *Hairenik* became important spaces for these searches. The notices published there reveal the afterlife of disappearance: violence persisted through missing information, fragmented families, and the absence of graves or definitive accounts of death. Nicholas Petoyan's 1919 notice provides a particularly revealing example. A native of Bardizag and graduate of its American missionary high school, Petoyan had moved to Constantinople before being conscripted into the Ottoman army. During the August 1915 deportations, he witnessed the destruction of his community. Four years later, he placed a notice in *Hairenik* seeking information about his father Sarkis, mother Yerani, sister Araksi, and relative Yervant.³⁴



³⁴ Armenian Immigration Project, <https://markarslan.org/ArmenianImmigrants/Public-ViewDetail-ArmenianImmigrants-Ads.php?submit=View&Staging=&SourcePage=Public-ViewSummary-ArmenianImmigrants-Combined-ByOriginPlace&SelectOriginCountry=Turkey&SelectOriginVSP=Izmit+%28mutesarifat%29&SelectOriginTown=Izmit+%28Baghtchedjik+%5BBardizag%5D%29&SelectSortOrder=ByName&Offset=0&argument1=Hairenik-1919-01-16-1-0> (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

By publicly naming his relatives and identifying them with Bardizag, Petoyan was attempting to reconstruct a social world that deportation had violently dispersed. His search illustrates how disappearance outlasted physical violence: the problem was not simply that his relatives had been killed, but that their deaths had been rendered uncertain and inaccessible. The search notice became an attempt to produce knowledge where the state had produced silence. Petoyan's later testimony established that his family, including his sister Mary, had been killed during the deportation, but this later certainty could not erase the years of uncertainty that preceded it.³⁵

Bardizag therefore demonstrates disappearance as a process extending from the destruction of communal leadership to the fragmentation of families and the postwar struggle to recover their histories. By removing leaders, dispersing populations, and withholding information about the dead, the state attacked not only the physical survival of the community but also the relationships and forms of knowledge through which it organized, mourned, and remembered itself. Disappearance destroyed not only individuals but the social networks through which Armenian society reproduced memory, authority, kinship, and claims to property.

Karen Jeppe's Reception Home, discussed at length in Section IV, was one institutional response to exactly this problem. The contrast between the two processes is analytically striking: genocidal administration made Armenians disappear from the record, while humanitarian documentation worked to make survivors legible again. That contrast should not be mistaken for a claim that humanitarian archives simply restored the truth. As Section IV emphasized, the record Jeppe's institution produced was shaped by the categories and purposes of rescue, identification, and reunification, and testimony collected there was simultaneously personal narrative and administrative instrument. But the underlying contrast; disappearance engineered by the state,

³⁵ Petoyan, Nicholas. Interview 61873. Interview by Andrew Kzirian. Visual History Archive, Hovannisian Oral History Collection, June 07, 1972. Accessed September 04, 2026.
<https://vha-usc-edu.proxy.binghamton.edu/testimony/61873>

legibility reconstructed by a private relief effort, remains one of the clearest afterlives of the expropriation this chapter traces.

Conclusion: The microhistory of Bardizag demonstrates that the Armenian Genocide was not solely a project of physical annihilation, but also a coordinated process of violent economic reorganization and capital transfer. By tracing the trajectory of this prosperous Marmara community, this chapter has proposed a critical revision of the standard formulation of the colonial boomerang. Rather than conceptualizing imperial violence as a force that merely travels from a distant geographical frontier back to the metropole, the Ottoman case reveals a more insidious domestic trajectory: the state actively turned frontier-style techniques of demographic engineering, irregular warfare, and selective dispossession inward, rendering a highly integrated and proximate population peripheral within the very heartland of the empire. Through the “three moments” of this boomerang forged on frontiers, carried by specialized perpetrators such as Ibrahim Bey, and applied to the interior region of the Marmara ; the Ottoman state and local forces gradually dismantled the defensive, social, political, and economic infrastructures of Armenian life, clearing the ground for mass plunder.

By analyzing this destruction through the lens of primitive accumulation, in this chapter, I argued that the extermination of the Armenians and confiscation of their material world including the expropriation of bodies and labor force, were structurally inseparable. The systematic confiscation of Armenian lands, vineyards, homes, and wealth was not an incidental byproduct of wartime panic, but a foundational, state-led intervention designed to underwrite the emerging Turkish national economy and consolidate a loyal national bourgeoisie. In the streets of Bardizag, this process materialized first through “staged disarmament” and administrative extortion which rendered the community entirely defenseless, and culminated in a “coerced marketplace” in which Ottoman state official and neighboring populations liquidated Armenian assets under conditions of

extreme duress. Crucially, this primitive accumulation was not limited to land and property; it extended directly to human capacities, bodies, and labor. The political economy of the genocide relied on heavily segmented and gendered logic of extraction. For the male “productive remnant,” survival was conditioned on unfree, conscripted labor- first in grueling auxiliary labor battalions and later as captive artisans stitching military uniforms in Cemal Pasha’s factories in Aleppo and Damascus.

The case of Bardizag thus illustrates in concrete terms how violence, legality, and economy converged to produce both material profit and political legitimacy. These dynamic challenges conventional distinctions between destruction and production, showing that the annihilation of a people was inseparable from the creation of a new social order. The interplay between violence and labor is crucial to understanding this period. The very process of mass deportation, through dispossession, starvation, and terror, transformed Armenians into a source of cheap and compliant labor. Violence functioned not only as an instrument of destruction but also as a mechanism of control, stripping individuals of property, mobility, and bargaining power. Under Cemal Pasha’s administration in Syria, this violence was rechanneled into a system of coerced productivity: artisans, workers, and even widows were rendered dependent on military, provisioning and subject to the state’s authority through labor. In this sense, the factories and road projects that Cemal oversaw in Aleppo and Damascus were exploitative spaces where survival was possible only through submission to a regime that had first annihilated the means of independent existence. The colonial boomerang provided the operational machinery for the systemic expropriation of gendered labor by turning the techniques of frontier counterinsurgency inward against the Armenian heartland. The state-sponsored breakdown of community defense created the specific vulnerability required for what the chapter identifies as “recursive expropriation,” exemplified by the experience of Arshalous, who was repeatedly seized and resold as a confiscated resource across multiple households. The colonial logic of treating subjects as “spoils of war” was thus institutionalized within the domestic sphere through the concept of

“hollow freedom” where juridical forms like marriage were repurposed as instruments of possession to absorb Armenian labor into Muslim-Turkish household. Ultimately, the boomerang did not eliminate populations; it converted the expropriated bodies and “unwaged service” of women into the “hidden precondition” for the relative freedom and social reproduction of the favored populations within the emerging national economy. Through “recursive expropriation” women were repeatedly seized and sold across households, their bodies and labors treated as “spoils of war”. The sources from Bardizag remind us that expropriation was not confined to property alone; it extended to bodies, in, and the very capacity to sustain life. Attending these intertwined histories of gender, labor, and dispossession allows us to grasp how capitalism, nationalism, and state violence operated together to reshape both space and society in the early twentieth century.